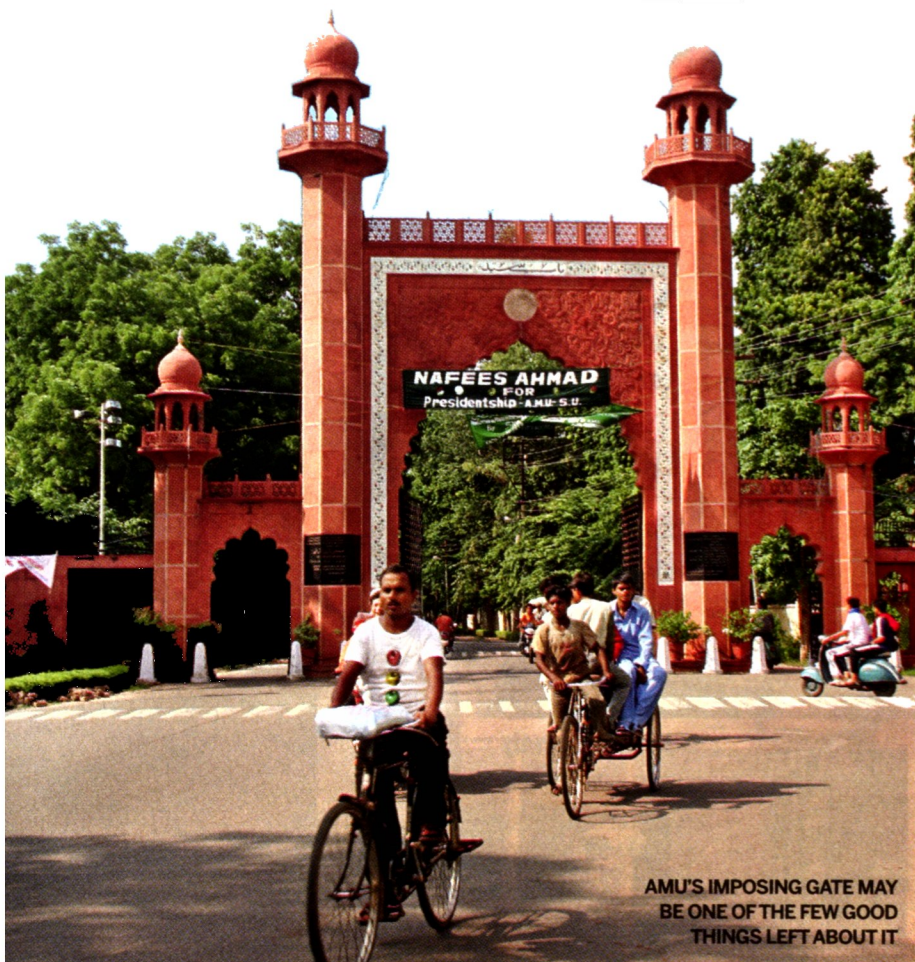




AMU'S IMPOSING GATE MAY BE ONE OF THE FEW GOOD THINGS LEFT ABOUT IT

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Institutional MELTDOWN

The suicide of a gay professor turns the spotlight on the mess this once hallowed university has become

| By Farzand Ahmed |

The suicide by Shrinivas Ramchandran Siras has stripped away the veneer of a 90-year-old institution which is now in the news more for its electronic surveillance than its intellectual environment. Even as its Vice-Chancellor (v-c) P.K. Abdul Azis faces serious charges of corruption which are being investi-

gated by a panel of two retired judges, four senior Aligarh Muslim University (AMU) officials—Proctor Zubair Khan, Deputy Proctor Farid Khan, Public Relations Officer Rahat Abrar and the v-c's Media Advisor NAK Durrani—are facing charges under various sections of the Indian Penal Code for criminal trespassing, physical assault and forcible disturbance of privacy rights. With its 400 security guards, eleven local intelligence units and 57 high-

powered CCTV cameras monitoring the movement of its 1,100 teachers and 38,000 students, the university has completed the transition to becoming an enclave of paranoia.

AMU is no stranger to trouble. In the last 15 years, it has been closed down indefinitely six times. Three murders have taken place inside and outside the campus since September 2007. Violence reached a new level when on the night of September 16, 2007, students burnt down the v-c's Lodge, the proctor's office and the staff club to protest the murder of fellow students. In the same month, women students indulged in violence on the basis of rumours that a student had been raped. The university was closed and the students' union was scrapped. In another incident in October 2009, students launched an agitation demanding the ouster of the v-c. The provocation was the killing of B.Sc student Shahnawaz Alam near the Aligarh railway station. The administration cracked down to quell the student agitation, closing the university and asking the students to vacate hostels.

But even for a central university in steady decline, this may well be the lowest point. Teachers don't have individual chambers for their academic work and there are no restrooms for the women faculty but the university was able to spend Rs 10 crore on installing CCTVs. In most departments, M.Phil classes had been stopped as students were forced to go in for Ph.Ds instead. Likewise, in the Modern Indian Languages Department, which teaches seven regional languages, there are hardly any students as they are not encouraged to pursue different languages. Students are not allowed to raise any questions. Even meetings held on the campus to exchange views are now subject to police monitoring.

As if having a network of intelligence—local intelligence units and CCTVs everywhere—was not enough, the authorities have stepped up moral policing of students and teachers, of the kind responsible for Siras' suicide. In a resolution, the Aligarh Muslim University Teachers' Association